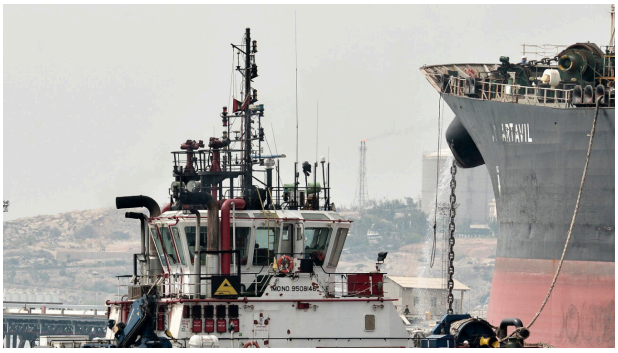
The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Iran warned of retaliation after Donald Trump wrote on social media that **America** had “obliterated every MILITARY target” on Kharg Island, the site of Iran’s main oil-export terminal, but left its oil infrastructure intact. America’s president vowed to “reconsider this decision” if Iran continues to impede shipping through the Strait of Hormuz. America is reportedly sending at least another 2,000 marines and another warship to the Middle East.

The price of **Brent crude**, the global oil benchmark, rose above $103 a barrel for the first time in nearly four years. Oil prices continue to rise despite Mr Trump temporarily lifting sanctions on Russian oil in a bid to stabilise energy markets. Meanwhile **stockmarkets** slid. The S&P 500 closed 0.6% lower while the tech-heavy NASDAQ fell by nearly 1%.

The European council proposed banning artificial-intelligence systems with “nudification” tools, which take images of clothed people and spit out plausible nudes, as as part of suggested amendments to the AI Act, Europe’s ground-breaking regulation. In January the European Union opened an investigation into Grok, a chatbot linked to Elon Musk’s social network X, after it generated millions of nude deepfakes of women and children.

A federal judge rejected subpoenas that America's **Department of Justice** served to the **Federal Reserve** over its criminal investigation into **Jerome Powell**. The judge said the government had insufficient proof that the central bank's chair had committed a crime, but that there was "a mountain of evidence" that the probe is an attempt to "pressure" Mr Powell into lowering interest rates or resigning.

Cuba's government held talks with the **Trump administration**, according to the country's president. Miguel Díaz-Canel told a press conference that discussions were aimed at "seeking solutions" after Mr Trump threatened that the socialist island could be his next target for a "friendly takeover". Last week Mr Trump made threats that Cuba "too" would "fall" after Iran.

Economic growth in **America** at the end of last year was weaker than first thought. The increase in **real GDP** was revised down to an annualised 0.7% for the final quarter, sharply lower than the previous estimate of 1.4%. In addition, **inflation** persisted at the start of 2026. The "personal consumption expenditures" price index, the Federal Reserve's preferred measure of inflation, rose by 0.3% in January.

France returned a sacred drum to **Ivory Coast**, a former colony. French administrators seized the Djidji Ayôkwé, which is a symbol of resistance for the Ebrié people, an indigenous group, in 1916. The sacred artefact was then displayed in Paris's Quai Branly-Jacques Chirac Museum. Françoise Remarck, Ivory Coast's minister of culture and Francophonie, called its repatriation "a moment of justice and remembrance".

Word of the week: Tilly tax, guild royalties paid by film studios for using AI-generated actors. Read the full story.

Photograph: Arash Khamooshi/The New York Times/Redux/eyevine

The seeds of a global food crisis

Two weeks of war have sent energy markets into turmoil. But the longer the Strait of Hormuz stays closed, the larger another crisis looms. The waterway is vital for more than just fuel. Gulf states rely on it to import much of their food—roughly 80% of the region's calories come from elsewhere. The likes of Qatar and the United Arab Emirates may be able to fly in supplies. But their regional peers, such as Lebanon, will face shortages; prices in Gaza have already shot up after Israel closed border crossings at the start of the war in Iran, limiting food aid to the territory.

Other consequences will be felt far more widely. Around a third of the world's trade in the raw materials used to make fertilisers passes through the Strait. Iran is one of the world's largest producers of urea, a crucial ingredient in synthetic nitrogen fertilisers. These are essential for modern agriculture: it is thought that half the global population would not be adequately fed without them. With planting season around the corner, a shortage could affect yields worldwide.

Photograph: Alamy

China and North Korea get back on track

The first passenger trains from China to North Korea since 2020 have arrived. That year the hermit kingdom shut itself off from the world to keep covid-19 out. That *cordon sanitaire* slowed trade to a near halt by 2021, but it has been growing since. Last year it climbed by 25% compared with the year before to $2.7bn, almost recovering -to pre-pandemic levels.

The reopened railways also reflect a rapprochement between the two countries. In 2024 North Korea sent troops to fight Russia's war against Ukraine. That annoyed China, which worries about its two unpredictable neighbours getting too chummy. Rather than try coercion, it has launched a charm offensive against Kim Jong Un, North Korea's third-generation dictator. He was an honoured guest at China's Victory Day parade (along with Vladimir Putin, Russia's president). Since then China has dropped its long-standing demand that North Korea denuclearise. Mr Kim is successfully practicing a family tradition: playing his patrons off against one another.

Photograph: Alamy

Millions of Asian migrants are stranded in the Gulf

Asian countries have been hit hard by America's and Israel's war in Iran. Spiralling oil prices have forced big energy importers, such India and the Philippines, to cut back on fuel consumption. But the human cost is also mounting. Around 24m migrant workers live in the Gulf—most of them from South and South-East Asia—and are at risk of being caught in the crossfire. There have been at least 12 reported casualties from Iranian strikes on nearby countries; 11 have been migrant workers, according to the *New York Times*.

Governments back home have been scrambling to arrange repatriation flights; many are scheduled for this weekend. More pain could follow if the war drags on. Remittances from the Middle East, equivalent to around 1% of GDP in India and up to 5% in Pakistan, are a crucial source of income for families. They are also vital foreign exchange for poorer economies. In Asia, the shock will not only be felt at the petrol pump.

Photograph: Hannah Reyes Morales/The New York Times/Redux/eyevine

Weekend profile: Balen, Nepal’s rapper turned prime minister

In some ways Balendra Shah, Nepal’s next prime minister, is an unlikely person to lead the country. At 35 he is half the age of the fossils he is replacing. He belongs to none of the three political parties that have held sway for two decades. And he promises to focus on bread-and-butter issues, in contrast to self-serving establishment politicians. Seen another way, he is an obvious national leader in 2026. He comes from an unorthodox background (rapping), has a large base on social media (1.3m Instagram followers in a country of 30m and a median age of 26), makes implausible promises (such as doubling incomes in five years), and is recognisable by his uniform of dark blazers and shades. He is, in short, a populist.

Known as Balen, he could have become prime minister six months ago. Huge youth protests in September toppled the government and led to the installation of a caretaker administration. Balen was a top choice for interim leader, but ruled himself out on the basis that it is better to win a five-year term than to serve as someone else’s opening act. On March 5th Nepalis voted overwhelmingly for him and his Rastriya Swatantra Party, giving it a near two-thirds majority in the lower house of parliament.

His route to the top started in the early 2010s, when he appeared on “Raw Barz”, a YouTube rap-battle show that involves flinging extempore insults over beats. Over time his tracks took on a political hue as he addressed the country’s entrenched corruption and poverty. In 2022 Balen stood for mayor of Kathmandu, Nepal’s capital, promising solutions to the city’s infrastructural shortcomings and civic ills such as bad sanitation and illegal businesses, and pointing to his background as a civil engineer.

Balen won, and has lived up to some of his promises. Kathmandu is cleaner today than it was four years ago. Illegal businesses have been removed. But he has also shown an aggressive side. Balen shuns the press, preferring social media. He offered no compensation or rehabilitation to vendors whose livelihoods were destroyed by his clean-up drive. And he has on occasion waged unnecessary culture wars, such as banning a Bollywood film from Kathmandu’s cinemas for referring to Sita, wife of the Lord Ram, as “India’s daughter”. (Nepal claims she was born there.)

His victory is a fresh start for Nepal, which voted democratically and mostly peacefully to confirm protesters’ rejection of the status quo. Balen is enormously popular and has a mandate to remake the country. But the optimism should be laced with caution. As one Nepali newspaper noted archly in an article about Balen in 2024, “unquestioning support sometimes paves the way for authoritarianism”.

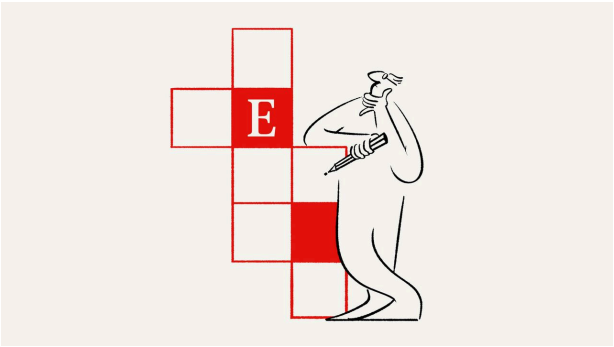


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - My Italian gift is moving (7)

2 across - Sound mixing artist (6)

3 across - Erin makes real din (7)

1 down - Young lady is drinking most of river (11)

Straight clues

1 across - Expat or asylum seeker (7)

2 across - Channel or inlet (6)

3 across - The third-largest island in Europe, also known as the Emerald Isle (7)

1 down - Southern American state, the birthplace of the Blues (11)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Carlos Flexa Ribeiro, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

Jan Redeby, Maseru, Lesotho

Enzo Orsini, Naples, Florida

They all gave the correct answers of: Licence to Kill, The Painted Veil, Cake by the Ocean, groom and ring. The theme is a wedding, where the couple needs a licence, the bride sometimes wears a veil, everyone eats cake and the groom and bride exchange rings.

The questions were:

Monday: Which was the second and last Bond film to feature Timothy Dalton?

Tuesday: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

Wednesday: What was the biggest hit by DNCE, a rock band whose lead singer was Joe Jonas?

Thursday: What is another term for someone who works as a stable hand?

Friday: Which word links the venues for a circus performance and a boxing match?

We know not through our intellect, but through our experience.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty